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Choose your route to market, then win it

CfD rounds, merchant, corporate PPAs and private wire, for onshore and offshore projects in the UK and Europe

Rounds are crowded. Winners pick their route early and arrive with the case built.

Process first, data second, agents third: how a team picks the right route and wins the round with the people it already has.

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Not legal, regulatory or investment advice.

00 AT A GLANCE

Choose the route before the round chooses it for you.

FIVE MESSAGES FOR YOUR LEADERSHIP TEAM

1. **The route is a decision, not a deadline.** Pick the anchor route for each project before the next round or buyer process picks it for you.
2. **Four routes, one project.** CfD rounds, merchant, corporate PPAs and private wire all draw on the same facts. Describe the project once.
3. **Know how the round pays.** In a pay-as-clear round your floor price decides whether you win. In a pay-as-bid round your bid is your price.
4. **Process first, data second, agents third.** Look at how your team chooses and bids today, fix the two biggest pain points, structure the evidence, then add agents.
5. **People choose and sign; agents carry the load.** Agents read the rules, assemble the evidence, draft and cross-check. Every round makes the next one better.

Who this paper is for

CEOs and heads of development, commercial and origination at renewables developers, IPPs and utilities in the UK and Europe, onshore and offshore.

Offshore seabed leasing rounds are a separate topic and a separate paper.

CONTENTS

01	Why now: more rounds, more routes	3
02	The four routes in plain words	4
	How the routes compare	5
	Choosing the anchor route	6
03	Process first: how you decide today	7
04	Winning the round, step by step	8
05	Inside the system	9
06	Self-check	10
07	Where to start	11

4 questions

find the anchor route for each project. Eight steps then win the round, with agents carrying the load and your people making every call.

> "The challenge is no longer building agents. It's building the system behind them."
>
> The Ignis view

01 WHY NOW

More rounds, more routes, the same team

Support rounds are bigger and more contested, the rules are changing across Europe, and buyers are pickier. Each project now has more ways to reach market, and each way asks for its own case.

14.7 GW

Awarded across 201 projects in the UK's seventh CfD round, the largest round to date.

2 times

Germany's August 2026 onshore wind round drew 5,250 MW of bids for 2,520 MW on offer.

3 times

France's latest onshore wind tender drew 2,378 MW for 800 MW, and the average price fell by €9.5/MWh.

The rules are moving

Across the EU, at least 30% of each country's auctioned renewable volume, or 6 GW a year, must now carry non-price criteria. Responsible business conduct, cybersecurity and the ability to deliver on time are tests to qualify. Resilience and sustainability can also be scored.

From 17 July 2027, new direct price support for wind and solar in the EU has to take the form of two-way contracts for difference or an equivalent. In the UK, CfDs for wind and solar now run for 20 years from AR7.

Buyers are pickier

Disclosed European PPAs came to 13.1 GW across 247 deals in 2025, down from 15.3 GW in 2024. Spain stayed the largest market at 3.9 GW.

Spain shows why one route is never enough. Its last renewables auction, in November 2022, offered 3,300 MW and awarded 45.5 MW. Projects there went to market through PPAs instead.

The UK clock: AR8 applications closed on 7 August 2026. The budget and auction notices are due on 19 November, with results expected in February 2027.

THE IGNIS VIEW

Policy, grid, supply chain and buyers each set their own calendar. Projects stall in the gaps between them. The industry needs coordination from policy and regulation through to the industrial plan, so projects move through each gate without pauses or drop-outs. A developer cannot fix that alone, but it can make its own route decision early, on one set of facts, and stop rebuilding the case for every counterparty.



02 THE FOUR ROUTES IN PLAIN WORDS

Four ways to sell the power, four different cases to make

Every route answers one question: who pays for the power, for how long and on what terms. What changes is who you must convince, and the evidence they want.

ROUTE 1

CfD round or state auction

A government round awards long-term price support. The UK runs CfD allocation rounds such as AR7 and AR8; France runs CRE tenders; Germany, the Netherlands and Spain run their own auctions.

You convince: the round's rules, with a sealed price and the evidence to qualify.

ROUTE 2

Merchant

The project sells at market prices, often with hedges, short-term deals or a trading partner. Common as the tail after a contract ends, and sometimes as the plan for part of the output.

You convince: your board and lenders that the price case holds.

ROUTE 3

Corporate or private PPA

A long-term contract with a buyer: a company, a utility or a trader. It can be physical, sleeved through a supplier, or virtual (financial). Terms, tenor and credit decide its value.

You convince: one buyer's energy, legal and credit teams.

ROUTE 4

Private wire

A direct cable from the project to a nearby user, such as an industrial site or a data centre, usually alongside a grid connection. Energy down the wire avoids most network charges, but it needs its own consent, land rights and licence position.

You convince: one user, the landowners on the route and the planners.

What recent rounds cleared at

Round	Technology	Price
UK AR7	Offshore wind, England and Wales	£91.20/MWh
UK AR7	Floating offshore wind	£216.49/MWh
UK AR7a	Onshore wind	£72.24/MWh
UK AR7a	Solar	£65.23/MWh
France, CRE	Onshore wind, weighted average	€77.08/MWh
Germany, EEG	Onshore wind, weighted average	4.79 ct/kWh

UK prices in 2024 money. France: latest onshore wind tender, July 2026. Germany: August 2026 onshore wind round.

02 HOW THE ROUTES COMPARE

No route wins on every count

The trade-off is always the same: certainty against upside and control. Read across a row to see what you give up for what you gain.

HOW THE FOUR ROUTES USUALLY COMPARE | IGNIS VIEW, MORE DOTS MEANS MORE OF IT

	CfD round	Merchant	Corporate PPA	Private wire
Price certainty	●●● Fixed strike price	●○○ Market price	●●○ Fixed or floored, per deal	●●○ Long contract, one buyer
Lender comfort	●●● Well understood	●○○ Needs hedges or more equity	●●○ Depends on buyer credit	●○○ Project on project risk
Upside you keep	●○○ Pays back above strike	●●● All of it	●●○ Shared, by structure	●●○ Shares network savings
Control of timing	●○○ Set by the round calendar	●●● Your own	●●○ Negotiated, can stall	●○○ Cable consent and land
Evidence to win	●●● Qualification and scoring	●●○ Lender price case	●●○ Buyer due diligence	●●● Consent, licence, metering
Onshore fit	●●● Main route in many markets	●●○ Often a later tail	●●● Strong where buyers exist	●●○ Only near large demand
Offshore fit	●●● Usual anchor	●○○ Rarely alone	●●○ Part of the mix	●○○ Rarely practical

Know how the round pays

The UK CfD is **pay-as-clear**: every successful project in a pot and year gets the same clearing price. Bidding lower raises your chance of winning, not your income, so the work that matters is an honest floor price.

Germany's onshore wind auctions are **pay-as-bid**: each winner gets its own bid. There the bid price is the income, and every euro counts twice.

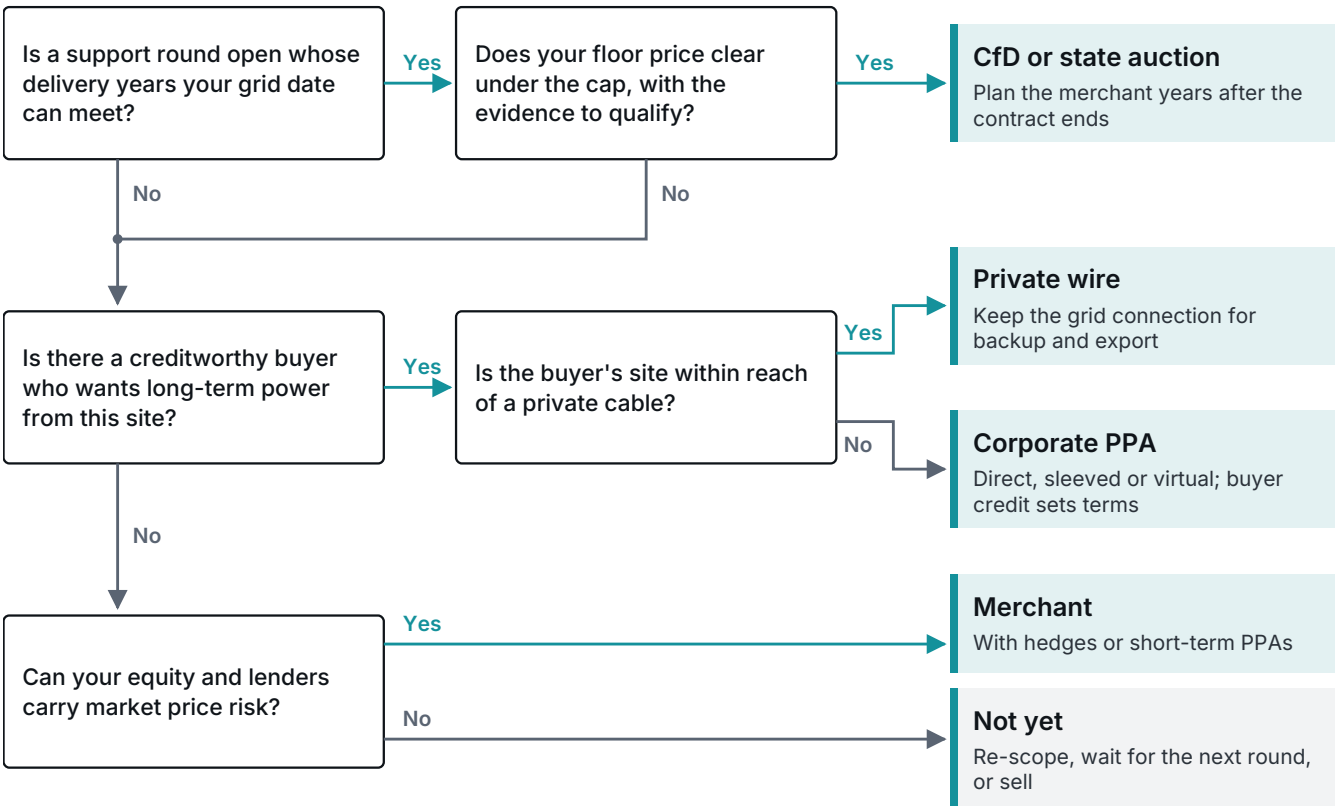
Most projects combine routes

A CfD covers the contract years and leaves a merchant tail. A PPA can cover part of the output while the rest sells at market. The useful question is which route is the **anchor**: the one that makes the project financeable.

02 CHOOSING THE ANCHOR ROUTE

Four questions find the anchor route

Ask them per project, at least once a year and whenever a round, a buyer or the grid date changes. The answer is the anchor; other routes can sit alongside it.



Offshore

Scale and capital cost usually make a state round the anchor, with corporate PPAs part of the mix in some markets. The grid date and the supply chain set which delivery year is credible.

Onshore

All four routes are live. A strong corporate buyer or a nearby large user can beat the next round on timing, and a round can beat a thin PPA market on price certainty.

Many markets, the same questions

The names change: CfD allocation rounds in the UK, CRE tenders in France, EEG auctions in Germany, renewables auctions in Spain and the Netherlands. The questions do not: can the grid date meet the delivery year, does the floor price clear, who else would buy the power, and who can carry the price risk.

Where teams slip: answering the first question from the round calendar instead of the grid date, and the second from last year's capex.

03 PROCESS FIRST

First, look at how you decide today

Most of the value lost in route and bid work is lost before and between documents, not inside them. So the first step is not a tool. It is a clear look at the process you run today, its bottlenecks and the reasons behind them.

1 The deadline picks the route

The next window decides where the project goes, not a comparison of routes.

Fix: a portfolio calendar and an anchor route per project, reviewed each quarter.

2 Evidence rebuilt every time

Land, consent, grid, yield and cost evidence is gathered again for each round or buyer.

Fix: one evidence library per project, with an owner and a date on every item.

3 The floor price set late

The walk-away is agreed in the final week, on inputs nobody has rechecked.

Fix: set the floor at the bid or no-bid gate, on current capex, yield and grid evidence.

4 The same project, told differently

Capacity, dates and prices drift between the round, a PPA offer and the board paper.

Fix: cross-checks as a step no submission can skip.

5 Lessons never written down

Results, clearing prices and buyer feedback stay in inboxes.

Fix: a short debrief that goes back into the record after every round.

Start with two

Pick the two loss points that cost you most, and find the reason for each. Fix those first. The rest can wait.

THE ORDER THAT WORKS

1 Process first	2 Data second	3 Agents third
What do you run today? Map how the route is chosen and how a bid is built. Remove steps that add nothing. Simplify what is left.	**What does it run on?** One record per project: facts, evidence and assumptions, versioned and owned.	**Then add the agents,** on the redesigned process, with named people deciding at each gate.

Revisit the real problem first

Why does a bid take as long as it does? Which steps exist because of a rule, and which because "we have always done it"? Is this the right round for this project at all? Automate a broken process and you get a faster broken process.

04 WINNING THE ROUND

Eight steps to win the round

The same steps work for a CfD application, a CRE tender, a PPA process or a private wire offer. Agents prepare; people decide at every step.

1 Route and calendar

AGENTS CARRY

Map every round, buyer process and deadline against the portfolio

YOU DECIDE

The anchor route for each project

2 Rules intake

AGENTS CARRY

Read the rules; turn requirements, dates and scoring into a checklist

YOU DECIDE

Scope and the deadline owner

3 Bid or no-bid

AGENTS CARRY

One page on fit, floor price, grid date and competition

YOU DECIDE

Go or no-go, with a written reason

4 Evidence

AGENTS CARRY

Pull land, consent, grid, yield and cost evidence; flag gaps and stale items

YOU DECIDE

What counts as current

5 Price and scenarios

AGENTS CARRY

Run the model on linked inputs; test scenarios and sensitivities

YOU DECIDE

The price and the walk-away

6 Draft and check

AGENTS CARRY

First drafts with every claim cited; match numbers across all submissions

YOU DECIDE

The story and every flagged conflict

7 Sign-off

AGENTS CARRY

Assemble the review pack and the decision log

YOU DECIDE

Sign-off under delegated authority

8 Lessons back in

AGENTS CARRY

Record result, clearing data and feedback in the project record

YOU DECIDE

What changes next round

Value a bid before you write it

> Bid value = **chance of winning** × **margin if you win** − **cost of bidding** − **chance of an error** × **cost of that error**

The last term is the one most teams leave out: a delivery year the grid date cannot meet, or a PPA offer that contradicts the round bid. Cross-checks cut it more cheaply than extra drafting hours.

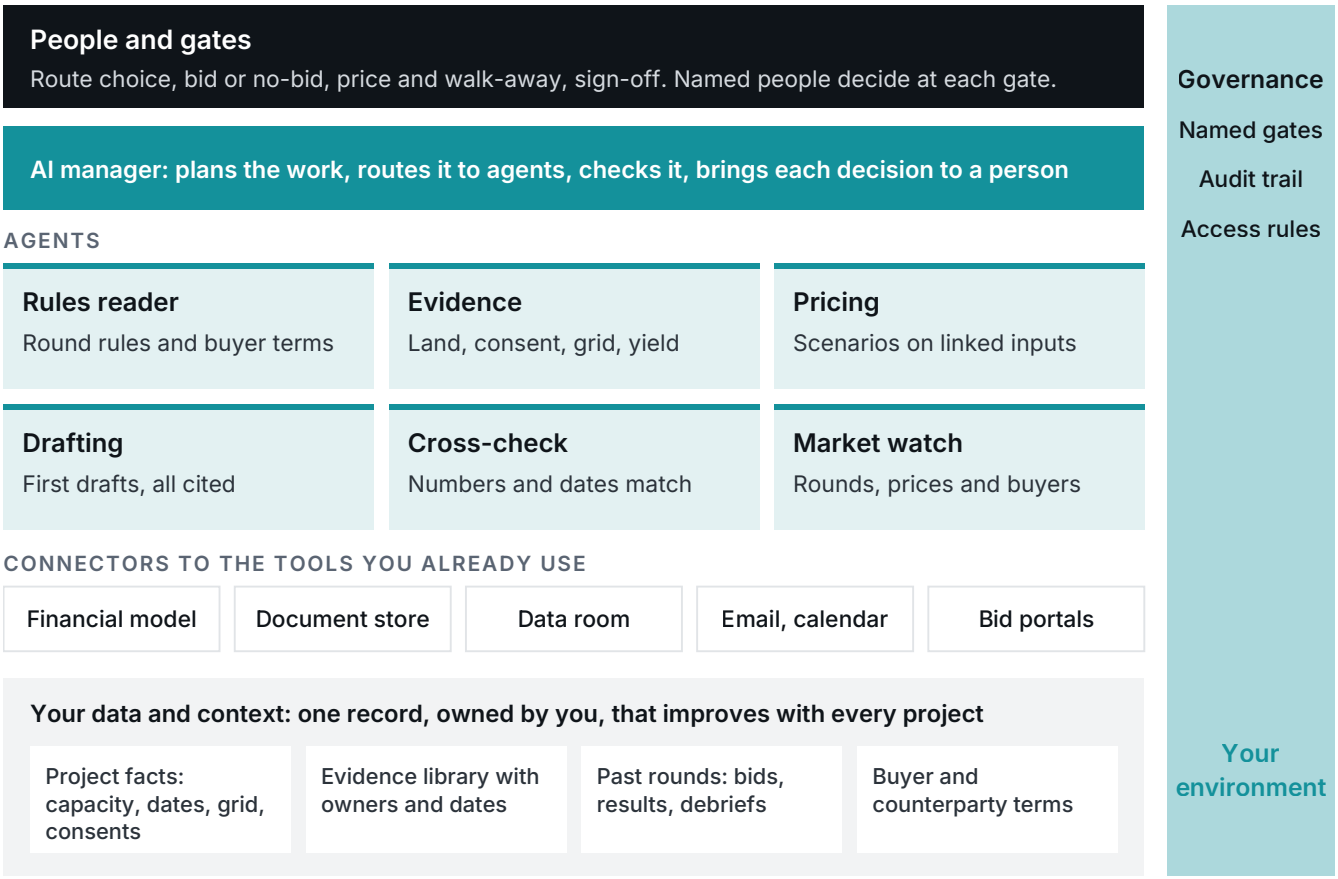
What agents change

- More rounds and buyers covered by the same team.
- Senior time moves from chasing and reconciling to price, partners and negotiation.
- Every claim traced to a source, every number matched.
- Each round leaves a better record for the next.

05 INSIDE THE SYSTEM

A governed system on your data, learning every round

Ignis builds the system around your team, on your own documents and in your own environment. It keeps the record, runs the repeatable work and brings every decision to a named person.



The AI manager

Breaks a goal such as "AR8 application for project B" into tasks, gives each to the right agent, checks the output and stops at each gate for a decision.

The record is yours

Facts, evidence, past bids and buyer terms stay in your environment under your access rules. The more rounds you run, the better it gets.

What stays human

The route, the price, the walk-away, partner terms and the signature. Relationships with buyers, communities and government.

> People keep the decisions. Agents carry the rules, the evidence and the first drafts.

06 SELF-CHECK

How ready is your team for the next round?

Ten yes or no questions. Tick what is true today, not what is planned.

- ☐ Each project has a named anchor route, reviewed in the last six months
- ☐ We hold a 12-month calendar of every round and buyer process across the portfolio
- ☐ Every bid has a written bid or no-bid decision with a floor price
- ☐ Each project has one evidence library, with owners and dates
- ☐ Our pricing model reads the latest capex, yield and grid inputs
- ☐ Capacity, dates and prices are cross-checked across every live submission
- ☐ We know which rounds pay as clear and which pay as bid, and price accordingly
- ☐ Drafting and checking do not depend on one or two people
- ☐ Results, clearing prices and buyer feedback go back into the record
- ☐ We have mapped at least one bid process end to end and know its two biggest pain points

Score: 0 to 3, start with the route decision and a bid or no-bid gate. 4 to 7, fix the evidence library and the cross-checks, then add agents. 8 to 10, you are ready to take on more rounds and buyers with the same team.

Questions for your team on Monday

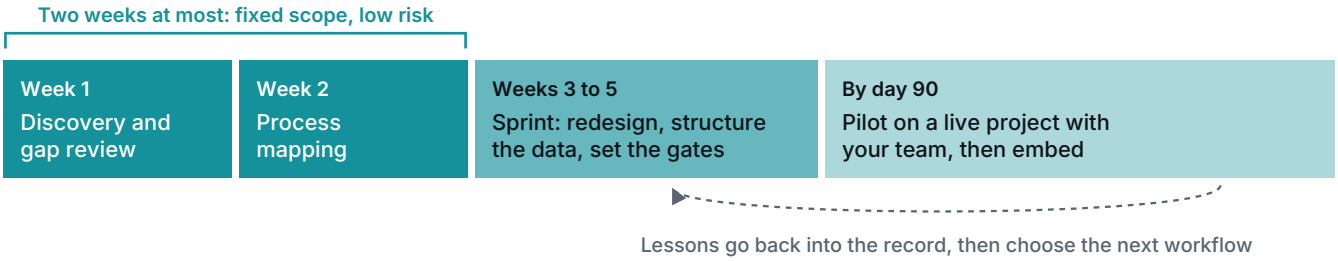
1. Which rounds and buyer deadlines fall in the next 90 days, and who owns each one?
2. What is our floor price for each, and when was it last tested?
3. Where does the same project appear with different numbers?
4. What did we learn from the last round, and where is it written down?



07 WHERE TO START

Start with your two biggest pain points, not with a platform

The first step is short and low risk: a discovery and gap review, then a map of how your team chooses routes and builds bids. Two weeks at most.



WEEK 1

Discovery and gap review

Your goals, your portfolio calendar, and the two biggest pain points in route choice and bidding, with their causes.

WEEK 2

Process mapping

One recent bid traced end to end on its own documents. What people keep, what agents carry, where the gates sit.

WEEKS 3 TO 5

Sprint

Redesign the process, structure the evidence and set the gates for the next live round.

BY DAY 90

Pilot

Your team runs a live round or buyer process on the new way of working, then embeds it.

> **Start with a discovery: two weeks at most, for a clear view of where agents will help.**
>
> Discovery and gap review, then process mapping

Guardrails

- Ignis advises and designs; your team decides.
- Your data stays yours, in your environment.
- Process before platform: tool-agnostic.

Want to talk through your route to market?

Bring one project and the next round or buyer process on your calendar. We will look at which route should anchor it and where your team loses time today. Talk it through with Yorik: **ignisleadership.com/contact**

+ NEXT READS AND ABOUT IGNIS

ALL STAGES

Agentic transformation for energy developers

The practical guide to introducing agents, from early stage development to financial close.

TENDER TO CLOSE

Procurement without the pauses

Supplier choice, contracts and the lender pack, with no gaps between gates.

WEEKLY

Signal, the newsletter

What is moving on the road to financial close. ignisleadership.com/insights

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About Ignis

Ignis Leadership is an advisory practice for onshore and offshore renewables developers, IPPs and utilities across the UK and Europe. We help teams win the right to develop and move projects to financial close, with fewer delays, fewer surprises and stronger terms. Expert-led, AI-assisted, on your data.

About Yorik Tisseau

Founder of Ignis Leadership. Yorik has worked in onshore and offshore renewables since 2013, from early stage development to financial close.

Talk it through with Yorik:
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Disclaimer. This paper offers a commercial view only. It is not legal, regulatory or investment advice. Market figures were checked in October 2026; round dates can change.